conductor Hito Kiho. "But I told [the other members] that if everyone puts their hands together, then with prayer and hard work, we can succeed."

Starting in January, Kiho put together a rigorous training regimen, with intense three-hour rehearsals three times a week. Many of the choir's members have full-time jobs, so they would turn up tired after a full day of work and then dive into practice. Kiho says that the members were so devoted that nobody missed even a minute of rehearsal.

While Kiho and the choir worked on their repertoire for the competition—eight songs, including western classics as well as indigenously written songs like 'Ampeu Shelo' by James Swu and 'Ode to Ganga' by Lipokmar Tzudir—Dr Pongen was busy putting together funds for the trip.

Finally, in early July, the group flew out to Gangneung, along with 323 other choirs from 46 countries. TNCC took part in two categories—Mixed Chamber Choir and Contemporary Choral Music—and won gold in both. That came as a surprise to Kiho, who had just allowed himself to believe that a podium finish was possible after two very satisfying performances. "It was a wonderful experience for me and the entire team," says Kiho. "We got to interact with people from all over the world, share our music, and see how they do things differently."

Dr Pongen and Kiho hope that the victories in Gangneung will lead to more interest and support for choral music in Nagaland and surrounding states. "We're seeing many more Nagas—or I should say, any Indian with a love for music—coming forward now," says Kiho. "I think in the coming years, we'll have many more choirs who will also try to take part in such competitions." ■

Bhanuj Kappal

BOOKS

A DISCORDANT LEGACY

The evolution of South Indian music as viewed through the life of the celebrity nadaswaram player **T.N. Rajarattinam Pillai**

The subject of Terada Yoshitaka's enquiry is the celebrity musician and nadaswaram player, T.N. Rajarattinam Pillai (1898–1956), made up with multiple narrative representations of him as a charismatic musician, as a dilettante, as a rebel who bridged two different performing traditions with flamboyant brilliance. The work draws heavily on the author's earlier doctoral dissertation; thus, there is a marked tendency to push a central argument insistently and, in the process, play down some of the complexities that marked the world of music performance in South India between the late-19th and mid-20th century. The argument itself is significant, namely that caste and social exclusion in southern India marked off two distinct but related segments of music-making—ritual orchestral ensembles performed by Isai Vellalar castes on the one hand, and public concerts of vocal music dominated by upper-caste Brahmin musicians on the other. The argument is not entirely new. However, what makes it compelling in Yoshitaka's case is how it's told through the life of one musician, who, thanks to his charisma, was able to straddle the two domains and reinvent himself as a polymath musician. Yoshitaka also comments on the extraordinary aura that Pillai commanded, which made him the subject of multiple interpretations by admirers and detractors. Where the argument falls short is the reluctance to look at Pillai as someone whose experiments (artistic and personal) were an expression of individual choice.

The book has a short but eloquent section on Pillai's early life and his encounters with his immediate networks of patronage as well as with the larger world of secular performance that had its epicentre in Chennai. Born into a family of hereditary Periya Melam musicians who performed at temples and enjoyed connections with *madams* (monastic centres) that sponsored Tamil literary and musical activity, Pillai drew on the advantages of unstinted support from these establishments. He very quickly made a name for himself in the performing circuits of temples in Tanjore. By the 1910s, he was a celebrity performer, sought after by wealthy notables and temple establishments. However, by this time, the world of performance was changing fast. The growth of a musical public in Madras spearheaded by Brahmin and upper-caste publicists who founded *sabhas*, organised public concerts and music appreciation societies, saw the articulation of a new aesthetics around vocal music associated with major 18th-century composers. Pillai wasn't oblivious to these developments, and, in fact, responded to them by undertaking a series of experiments with his own music to render it concert-worthy.



T.N. RAJARATTINAM PILLAI: Charisma, Caste Rivalry and the Contested Past in South Indian Music
by Terada Yoshitaka
SPEAKING TIGER
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In doing so, Pillai was helped by his talent and his investment in the new aesthetics that valued melodic elaboration and vocalisation. His mastery over the nadaswaram was acknowledged by all, even if his lifestyle of alcoholism and profligacy didn't sit easy with the moral preoccupations of the reformists. The question, however, remains whether we want to look at Pillai as someone who breached the bastion of classicism or whether he pursued his own aesthetic compulsions. Without denying the reality of caste and its dynamics that Yoshitaka's meticulous treatment draws attention to, it may be useful to remind ourselves that in reading Pillai's life retrospectively, we should not strip the artist of his musical agency. ■

Lakshmi Subramanian